32 Third Graders and One Class Bunny

By Phillip Done

I read *Charlotte's Web* and *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* every year, and every year when Charlie finds the golden ticket and Charlotte dies, I cry. I know when a child has gum in his mouth even when he is not chewing. I have sung "Happy Birthday" 657 times. I fix staplers that won't staple and zippers that won't zip, and I poke pins in the orange caps of glue bottles that will not pour. I hand out papers and pencils and stickers and envelopes for newly pulled teeth . . . I am a teacher.

INTRODUCTION

You were guessing something else, right? Well, I'm here to tell you that more men should become teachers - especially in elementary schools.

Want to do something really tough and brave? Something to change the world? Something adventurous . . . something really different? Well, you could join the Marines, or you could join the ranks of the Few. The proud. The male elementary school teachers!

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PS: 95% of the adults you work with will be WOMEN!! (wink)

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I plan lessons while shaving, showering, driving, eating, and sleeping. I plan lessons five minutes before the bell rings. I know what time it is when the big hand is on the twelve and the little hand is on the nine. I say the *r* in *library*. I do not say the *w* in *sword*. . . I am a teacher.

I put on Band-Aids and winter coats and school plays. I wear four-leaf clovers and dandelions in my shirt pocket that have just been picked with love at recess. I pray for snow days. I pray for Stephen to be absent.

I buy books about cats and dogs and sharks and volcanoes and horses and dinosaurs. I turn jump ropes and am base in tag. I am glad you can only get chicken pox once. . . I am a teacher.

I correct pencil grips and spelling mistakes and bad manners. I push in chairs all the way, push swings higher, and push sleeves up while children are painting. I can touch the paper cutter.

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I am a teacher . . . and I **used** to laminate everything, absolutely everything – posters, prints, bookmarks, birthday certificates, awards, library passes, name tags, file folders, book jackets, real estate calendars. You name it, I laminated it. They called me the laminating king.

It got pretty bad. Once Cathy sent me a note with a question. Attached was a sticky note. It said, "Please just answer question. Do not laminate." But now I won't go near the machine. Not even close. You see, one night I was in the staff room laminating my kids' art for Back-to-School Night. It was late.

Now, you know what a laminating machine looks like of course. It's about three feet wide and sits on a table. It has two big rolls of plastic. You put whatever it is you want to laminate in on one side. The paper rolls through the two big rolls of laminating plastic. The plastic is hot and adheres to the paper. And your paper comes out on the other side all nicely laminated. It's great.

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So there I was, carefully guiding each piece of artwork into the laminator, humming along, when all of a sudden, *(begin pantomime)* I felt this *tug!* I looked down. My tie was caught in the machine!

Immediately, I pulled back, but the tie was stuck. I tugged again. Still nothing. I jerked a third time. No luck. Meanwhile, I was still rolling into the machine. Oh my God, I thought. I am going to die!

I could see the headlines:

TEACHER FLATTENED IN LAMINATING MACHINE

TECHER SUFFOCATES TO DEATH IN HOT PLASTIC

JC PENNEY RECALLS ONE MILLION TIES

I slammed off the switch. It kept rolling. *(screaming)* Crap! It was the heat button. I pushed another button. It started rolling faster. *(yelling)* Nooooo! I reached under the table and fumbled for the cord. I found it. Thank God! I yanked it as hard as I could. Suddenly everything stopped.

I sighed, closed my eyes, and rested my chin on the edge of the table. I didn't move for about ten seconds. My head was about five inches away from the roller.

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(thinking out loud) How the hell am I going to get out of this thing? I couldn't undo my tie. The skinny part in the back had gone through too. Then I spotted some scissors on the counter. I tried to reach them, but they were too far away. Damn! What was I going to do?

(softly) Hellooooooo . . . . Hellooooo. Nobody answered. Oh my God, I thought. If I don't get out of here, the other teachers will find me here in the morning. I yelled louder. *(yelling louder)* ***Heeelp! Heeeeelp!***

Finally, after about ten minutes of screaming at the top of my lungs, Marion walked into the room.

PHILLIP: Don't laugh! Get me out of this thing! Grab those scissors over there and cut the tie. Just get me out of here! And stop laughing! It's not funny.

Marion cut the tie and I was saved. That night I made her swear to not tell a soul. But Marion is not good at keeping secrets. For weeks afterward, strangers would pass me in the supermarket, at the gas station – everywhere – point to my tie and start cracking up.

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I called my dad and told him the whole story. He couldn't stop laughing either. Until I told him it was his tie!

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(regaining his composure from the beginning of the selection) I am a teacher. . . I own one suit, two pairs of shoes, and eight boxes of graham crackers. I have every teacher mug that Hallmark ever made and every Save the Children tie too. I say, "Use two hands!" when they carry their lunch trays. I say, "Accidents happen," after they did not use two hands.

I sign library passes and yearbooks and new casts. I attend soccer games and Little League championships and funerals for guinea pigs. I answer to both "Mom" and "Dad." . . . I am a teacher.

I hope April Fool's Day is on a Saturday. I have worn green marker, red paint, yellow chalk dust, glue stick, and glitter all on the same day. I hate glitter.

I can make a telescope out of a toilet paper roll and a totem pole out of oatmeal boxes. I can make snowflakes out of

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coffee filters and a space shuttle out of a Pringles can too. [But] I can only say my ABCs if I sing them. . . I am a teacher.

I call on children whose hands are not raised. I know when a child does not understand. I know when a child is not telling the truth. I know when a child was up too late last night. I know when a child needs help finding a friend.

I am a teacher . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

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